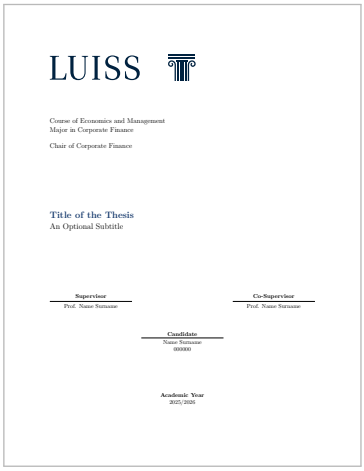
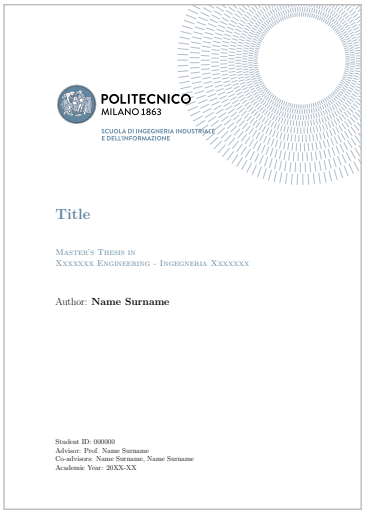
academicthesis

One thesis class, one package per university

An introduction to the LUISS and Politecnico di Milano packages



LUISS



Politecnico di Milano

Luca Salvatore

Class version 0.2.0 • October 2026

Contents

1 Why academicthesis exists 2

2 How it is built 2

3 The LUISS package 3

4 The Politecnico di Milano package 3

5 What both packages share 4

6 Where to go next 5

Acknowledgements and licence 5

1 Why academicthesis exists

Every university prescribes how a thesis must look: which logo goes on the cover and where, how the degree programme is named, who is listed as supervisor or advisor, which page size and margins to use, in which language the labels are printed. Students usually meet these rules in one of two ways: a Word document to imitate, or a LaTeX template to copy and edit by hand. Both put the burden on the student, and both break the moment the thesis is written in another language, has two supervisors instead of one, or moves from a bachelor's to a doctoral degree.

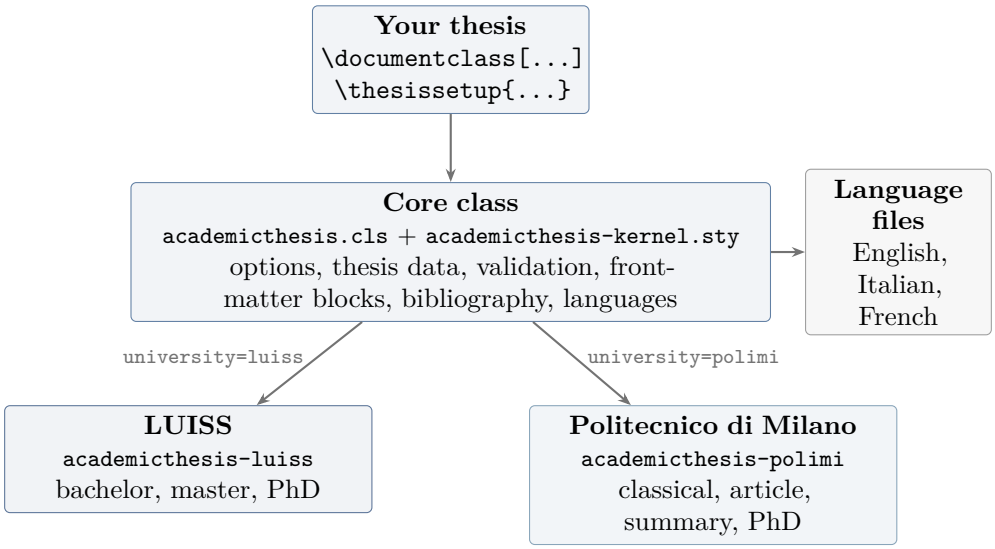
academicthesis turns these rules into a LaTeX class. A student states *which* university, degree and language apply, fills in the data of the thesis once, and the class produces the cover page, the front matter and the page layout that the university expects:

```
\documentclass[university=luiss, master, language=english]{academicthesis}
\documentclass[university=polimi, master, format=classical]{academicthesis}
```

The same thesis text compiles under either line. What changes is the university package that the class loads behind the scenes.

2 How it is built

The project is a *collection of packages* with a shared code base, rather than one large class. Each university is a separate package; a user only needs the core and the package of their own university.



The core class (`academicthesis.cls`) knows nothing about any particular university. It reads the class options, stores the thesis data given with `\thesissetup`, checks that nothing required is missing, loads fonts, languages and the bibliography, and provides the blocks every thesis has: abstract, statement of originality, acknowledgements and dedication.

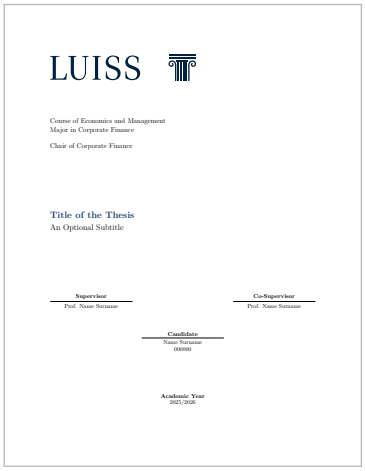
A university package (`academicthesis-<university>.sty`) contributes everything that is specific to one institution: the base class and page geometry, the cover page for each degree, the data that institution requires, and its own wording of the labels (for example "Advisor" instead of "Supervisor").

Language files hold every printed word, so labels follow the language of the thesis. English, Italian and French are provided, and a university can override any single label.

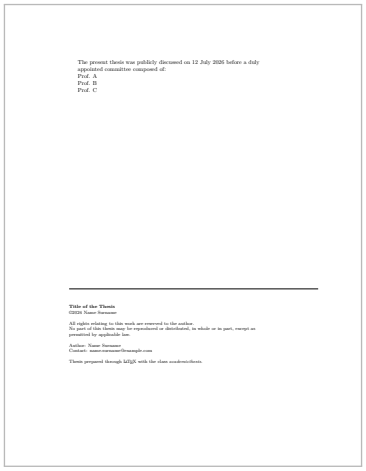
The packages find each other *by name only*, never by folder. Once installed in a TEX tree, a student can therefore install the core and just one university package; inside the repository, a small search-path file lets the examples compile directly. Adding a university means adding one folder, without touching the core or the other universities.

3 The LUISS package

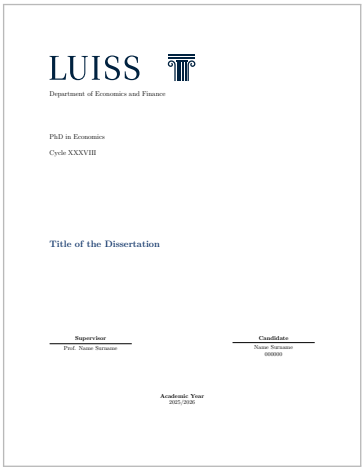
academicthesis-luiss produces the LUISS Guido Carli thesis layout for bachelor's, master's and doctoral theses.



Bachelor's / master's cover



Second page



PhD cover

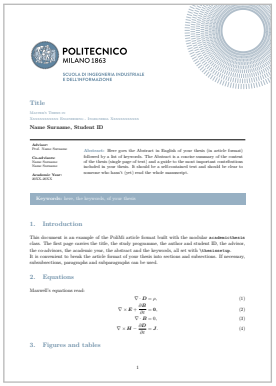
- **Cover page.** The LUISS logo, the degree programme ("Course of . . . "), an optional major and the chair ("Chair of . . . "), the title in LUISS blue, then supervisor(s), co-supervisor(s) and candidate in labelled columns, and the academic year at the bottom.
- **PhD cover.** Same structure: the department under the logo, "PhD in . . . " and the doctoral cycle where a bachelor's or master's cover has the course and the chair.
- **Second page.** The examination commission (or a statement that the thesis has not been defended) and a copyright block. It is printed by default and can be switched off.
- **Adjustable cover.** Logo, title, course, major and department lines can each be aligned left, centre or right with `\luissthesissetup`; the logo size and file can be changed too.
- **Defaults.** book base class; author–year bibliography (biblatex with biber).

4 The Politecnico di Milano package

academicthesis-polimi reproduces the thesis layouts of Politecnico di Milano. One option, `format`, chooses among four of them; the package then picks the right base class, page size, colours, cover and headings.



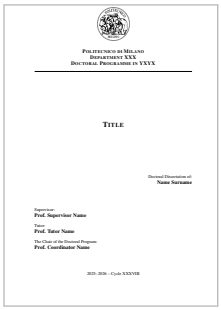
`classical`



`article`



`summary`



`phd`

Format	What it is	Built on
`classical`	The full thesis as a book: cover page, abstracts, chapters. The default.	book, 12pt, two-sided, A4
`article`	The thesis as a paper: a header block with the abstract on page 1, then sections.	article, 11pt, A4
`summary`	The Executive Summary: two columns under a blue page header.	article, 11pt, two columns, A4
`phd`	The doctoral dissertation.	book, 10pt, 17×24 cm or A4

Every PoliMi thesis has an English and an Italian abstract, so both languages are always loaded. Labels follow PoliMi's own wording ("Advisor", "Student ID", "Tesi di Laurea Magistrale in") in English or Italian, according to the language of the thesis.

Credit: the PoliMi layouts are Politecnico di Milano's design

The page designs reproduced by academicthesis-polimi are **not original work of this project**. They come from the official LaTeX templates provided by Politecnico di Milano:

- the thesis templates of the School of Industrial and Information Engineering (Scuola di Ingegneria Industriale e dell'Informazione, "Scuola 3I"), revision of October 2021: *Thesis classical format*, *Thesis article format* and *Executive Summary*, on which the `classical`, `article` and `summary` formats are modelled;
- the PoliMi doctoral dissertation template (`phdthesis.sty`, `phdtitle.sty`), on which the `phd` format is modelled.

The cover arrangement, colours (`bluepoli`), chapter and section styles, running headers, the "raggiera" background and the Politecnico logos and seal all belong to Politecnico di Milano and its template authors. This package re-implements those layouts on top of the shared academicthesis core, so that they are selected with a class option and share the core's data handling, validation and multilingual blocks. The credit for the design goes to Politecnico di Milano.

5 What both packages share

Because both packages sit on the same core, a thesis gets the same behaviour whichever university it is written for:

- **One place for the data.** Title, candidate, degree, supervisors, academic year and the rest

are given once, with `\thesissetup`, using the same key names at every university.
- **Clear errors.** A missing required field stops the compilation with a message naming the field and showing an example, instead of producing a cover with a blank space.
- **Several languages in one thesis.** The abstract, statement of originality, acknowledgements and dedication each take a `language` option, so an English thesis can carry an Italian abstract with the correct heading, "Keywords" label and hyphenation.
- **Counting and gender.** Labels switch between "Supervisor" and "Supervisors" by themselves, and in Italian between "Candidato" and "Candidata".
- **Bibliography that always compiles.** biblatex with biber is used when available, with a fallback to natbib and BibTeX behind the same two commands, `\addbibresource` and `\printbibliography`.
- **Nothing imposed beyond the layout.** Each package loads only what its layout needs; hyperref, tikz, extra maths packages and the bibliography style remain the student's choice.

6 Where to go next

- The **User guide** (`academicthesis-user-guide.pdf`, in this folder) explains every class option and data field, lists what each university and format requires, and gives complete examples.
- The **showcases** (`showcases/` in the repository) are complete theses that compile as they are; copying the one closest to your case is the fastest way to start.
- The **architecture guide** (`doc/ARCHITECTURE.md`) is for those who want to add a university or a language.

Acknowledgements and licence

The academicthesis core class and its packages are released under the LaTeX Project Public Licence (LPPL) 1.3c or later; copyright 2025–2026 Luca Salvatore.

The Politecnico di Milano layouts are based on the official templates of Politecnico di Milano, as detailed in the box above; their design, and the Politecnico di Milano name, logos, seal and graphic elements, belong to Politecnico di Milano. The LUISS name and logo belong to LUISS Guido Carli. academicthesis is not published by either university: before submitting a thesis, always check the current rules of your school or doctoral programme.